Unit 5: Writing a video brief

A video brief summarizes the key points of a video in sequential order to help the reader (e.g. a video creator) imagine what the final product will look and sound like.

In this unit, you will **write a video brief with 6-10 rows to present one or more solutions to or a life hack for a common problem using one required image**. (However, this format can be adopted for any type of video.) The required image you will be given, as well as other images you would like to include in the video, must be clearly described. You will not show any actual images.

A video brief has two main columns of text: **voice** and **visuals**. In the Voice column will be the words the viewer will hear said during the video. These should be full sentences. Since this is an informal video, the language can be slightly informal, although it must still be grammatically correct. For example:

You don't have to use a stair machine at the gym. Just take the stairs at work!

The Visuals column will describe what images the viewer sees as the corresponding words in the Voice column are heard. These do not have to be full sentences, but should be clear descriptions of what the viewer will see. They should support what is being heard. For example, to accompany the text being said in the example from the Voice column above, this may be the visual:

Still image of a man walking up a flight of stairs

Exercise 1. Refer to *Writing skill: Supporting a text with images* (p. 68) for guidelines on how to choose what to place in your Visuals column. Discuss the benefits and drawbacks of each of the following types of visuals.

A. A photograph	E. A moving image	I. A wide shot
B. An illustration	F. A table / a chart / a graph	J. An aerial shot
C. A still image	G. A diagram	K. Text on screen
D. A series of stills	H. A close-up	L. A presenter talking directly to the camera

A video brief describing one or more solutions to or a life hack for a common problem should have the following components:

1. An informative title

The title of the video brief should succinctly explain what the video will show, e.g. *Video brief: Ways to add exercise to your daily routine*, *Video brief: How to keep your beverage cool*. Note how the first title tells the reader that there will be several solutions for a problem, while the second one informs them there will likely be one solution or hack.

2. An introduction

The first few rows of the video brief should give an introduction to the issue that the video is going present solutions or a hack for, and if needed, the causes of the problem. Look at how this is done in the following example.

Voice	Visuals
We can all agree that exercise is a great thing to have as part of your daily routine if possible.	A series of stills of people running, swimming, lifting weights, walking on a treadmill, and playing badminton
Unfortunately, with our busy schedules, finding time to go to a gym each day can be really difficult.	A photograph of a page from a day planner with every hour filled in with an event
The outcome is that many people do not exercise each day.	A wide shot of a woman looking sadly at the outside of a building with the word "Fitness" written on it

3. The main video content

These are the rows that describe the solutions/hack. The Voice column should contain the grammatically correct sentences the viewer will hear, while the Visuals column will give short, informative descriptions of what they will see. For this video brief, you must include a description of one given image. It is up to you how you will incorporate it into your video brief. Note how the following required image is described in A and B. Which gives the better description?

Required image

A.

Voice	Visuals
Can't find time to lift weights at the gym? Strengthen your arms by lifting water bottles when you're at the supermarket.	A man holds three bottles of water between two rows of shelves

B.

Voice	Visuals
Can't find time to lift weights at the gym? Strengthen your arms by lifting water bottles when you're at the supermarket.	An illustration of a man holding up three clear bottles with both hands (two in his right hand and one in his left) standing between two rows of shelves with bottles

4. A conclusion

The last few rows conclude the video by summarizing the problem and the solutions/hack. The Voice column might repeat key concepts, but should not use the same words as the introduction.

Voice	Visuals
Our busy lives may make it hard to go to the gym, but there is no reason why you cannot still exercise every day. All you have to do is modify daily activities into fun workouts.	A woman running up a flight of stairs holding a large shopping bag in each hand Text on screen: You can exercise anywhere!

Exercise 2. Read the following video brief, and complete the following tasks.

A. Determine which rows:

1. introduce the problem
2. explain the cause of the problem
3. describe the solutions/hacks
4. give a conclusion to the video

B. Choose the best title for the video brief.

1. How to prepare instant noodles
2. How to improve your instant noodles
3. How to make the firmest instant noodles
4. How to quickly cool your instant noodles

C. Determine which row has a description of the following image.

Row	Voice	Visuals
1	Instant noodles are a quick and easy meal for busy people like yourself, but have you ever found your instant noodles to be a bit soggy?	An illustration of a woman looking sadly at instant noodles hanging limply from a pair of chopsticks
2	When instant noodles are soaked in liquid for too long, the starch in them absorbs water and softens the noodles.	Simple diagram showing small, thin noodles absorbing water and becoming enlarged
3	However, there is no reason to suffer soggy, mushy instant noodles. Let's see how to make instant noodles that are firm and chewy!	An illustration of the same woman now smiling widely at instant noodles twirled around a fork that are hanging into a bowl full of instant noodles
4	The process is not hard at all, and it is not all that different from how you normally make instant noodles. First, boil two and a half cups of water in a large pot.	Woman pouring two and a half cups of water into a large metal pot on a stove
5	Add the seasoning packet from the package of instant noodles and anything else you would like, such as pieces of chicken or diced carrots, to make a broth. Boil for one minute.	Close-up of a digital timer set to 1 minute
6	Place the square of instant noodles into the boiling broth.	Close-up of two hands dropping a square of instant noodles into a pot of boiling brown broth
7	Press the noodles down with chopsticks or a fork to keep them submerged in the broth.	A still image of a pair of chopsticks and a fork

8	After two minutes have passed, pull the noodles up from the broth, and fan them for two minutes. You can use the pot lid or fold a paper fan.	Woman fanning instant noodles with a paper fan while looking at a digital timer set to two minutes
9	The reason why you fan the noodles is that the flow of air will stop the cooking process, resulting in noodles with a firm texture.	Simple diagram of air moving across instant noodles
10	Return the noodles to the broth, take the pot off the heat, and enjoy! Say good-bye to soggy noodles forever!	Woman happily eating instant noodles from a bowl using chopsticks Text on screen: Bon appétit!